FINANCE / OPERATIONAL CONTROLS / WORKFLOW DESIGN

Financial Controls & Corporate Credit Card Management Transformation

Building accountable spending practices, program-level budget visibility, and a more reliable credit card reconciliation cycle.

ORGANIZATION	ROLE & PROJECT SCOPE
Family Solutions	**Operations Manager | Corporate credit card controls within AP**

Executive overview

When I assumed oversight of accounts payable at Family Solutions, I found that corporate credit cards were issued without meaningful written spending guidance, consistent receipt accountability, or effective budget monitoring. Cards were in use across multiple financial institutions and more than two dozen employees had purchasing access. The resulting work was fragmented, difficult to verify, and a barrier to timely month-end close.

I designed and implemented an agency-wide credit card control process: formal cardholder expectations, program-specific budgeting tools, structured receipt collection, an AP review and import workflow, automated data preparation, and independent reconciliation checks. I continuously refined the process based on user feedback, exceptions discovered during monthly cycles, and changes to IT security restrictions.

At a glance

20+	~500	10th
employees with purchasing access	monthly receipts on the primary account	of the month: close deadline made achievable

The problem to solve

- Cardholders had signed only a basic acknowledgment of receiving a card; there was no substantive policy covering business-only use, budget expectations, spending limits, or documentation requirements.
- Receipts were routinely missing or collected through repeated follow-up; expense coding was inconsistent and program budgets could drift off track without timely visibility.
- The volume of transactions created substantial manual work at the beginning of each month, delaying AP reconciliation and the broader book-closing process.

The objective was not to automate AP in its entirety. It was to bring structure, preventive controls, and reliable verification to a large, high-friction component of AP: corporate credit card spending.

SOLUTION DESIGN

Establishing controls and shared accountability

1 - Formal expectations for cardholders

I created a dedicated credit card policy and procedures covering authorized company purchases, documentation, spending responsibilities, and program budget limits. Each person receiving credit access reviewed and signed the requirements alongside the applicable program budget. This replaced the prior practice of simply recording when a card had been received.

2 - Budgets usable by the people spending the money

I built Excel registers and dashboards tailored to each program. Cardholders entered a purchase and selected its expense category; the register displayed the current budget, total spent, and remaining balance. Dashboards showed category-level over- and under-budget positions. After gathering feedback from program leaders, I adjusted the layouts and calculations to better fit how the programs operated.

For programs whose budgets depended on resident or client volume, I linked daily client-count/ratio datasets to calculate an average monthly census and support more appropriate budgeting assumptions.

3 - A defined receipt collection and coding chain

RESPONSIBLE PARTY	CONTROL / ACTION
Cardholder	Record purchases, classify them in the program register, and submit receipts.
Office specialist (each building)	Track receipt completion for local cardholders, compare receipts with statements, and assemble documentation for AP within five days of the statement date.
AP specialist	Review receipts against descriptions and coding, resolve questions, allocate eligible shared costs, and prepare transactions for QuickBooks Online.
Operations Manager (me)	Perform final balancing and reconciliation review, assess dashboard exceptions, and communicate spending or control concerns to program directors and executive leadership.

4 - Reinforcement rather than follow up alone

I scheduled card-specific email reminders for statement dates so employees knew when to submit receipts. I also personally recognized people who had completed 100% of their documentation by the statement date. Timely recognition was part of encouraging consistent behavior, not just correcting missed requirements.

WORKFLOW & CONTROLS

Automating the mechanics - without removing judgment

I built the workflow around tools available in the Microsoft 365 environment, with QuickBooks Online remaining the accounting system of record. The goal was to eliminate repeatable data handling while preserving opportunities to catch inaccurate receipts, coding, and allocations.

01

Receive and prepare source data

Where vendors could email reports as CSV or Excel files, Power Automate saved them into designated folders. Power Query combined, cleaned, and standardized the incoming transactions.

02

Prepare a stable AP review sheet

The original VBA process moved cleaned transaction data into a persistent review sheet so rows would not shift after AP added information. When third-party IT restrictions prevented macro use, I revised parts of the workflow using Excel automation.

03

Preserve meaningful AP verification

I initially allowed program spreadsheet entries to feed the AP sheet automatically. After observing that this removed a useful check, I restored manual AP entry of the added coding fields. AP verified that receipts matched the described purchase and that the expense category was appropriate.

04

Support allocation and accounting import

I built dropdown-driven calculations for shared building expenses spanning multiple programs. The output columns aligned with QuickBooks Online import requirements, reducing duplicate entry. I later corrected split-allocation formulas when odd-cent transactions exposed a one-cent rounding exception.

05

Reconcile independently and escalate issues

After posting, I ran a script comparing three data sources: the office specialists' receipt reports, the AP import CSV, and the QuickBooks export. I investigated differences, reviewed transaction dashboards, and communicated exceptions and budget concerns.

RESULTS & LEARNING

What changed for the business

Operational outcomes

Faster AP cycle. The primary account, with more than 10 cardholders and roughly $30,000 in monthly activity, could generate about 500 receipts. Based on my retrospective estimate, the AP specialist's work for that account declined from roughly 30 hours to about one workday, including receipt verification, coding review, entry preparation, and related follow-up. My final reconciliation and management review were additional steps.

More reliable close. Improved receipt timeliness, standardized handoffs, structured review, and import-ready data made it possible to close the books by the 10th of the month, something that had previously been difficult to achieve.

Stronger financial controls. Receipt collection improved, lost or missing documentation became less common, and spending responsibilities were clearer. The organization also saw improved findings in its third-party financial audits; precise audit measures were not retained for this summary.

Better budget visibility. Program leaders could monitor spending as it occurred, and I could identify coding problems, budget assumptions that no longer matched pricing, and categories requiring operational intervention.

From accounting data to operational action

The control system also revealed business problems beyond reconciliation. One residential program showed a sharp increase in food delivery costs. I traced the pattern to operational circumstances: the employee who normally handled meal preparation was absent, and staff on another shift were ordering delivered meals. I brought the findings into leadership discussions and used the analysis to support a proposed staffing solution, hiring a part-time cook, instead of treating the expense spike as a bookkeeping anomaly.

What the project demonstrates

This work combined financial control design, change management, program-level budgeting, practical automation, independent reconciliation, and management reporting. It also reinforced an important principle: automation is valuable only when it supports reliable decisions. I intentionally removed automation that bypassed human review, and I revised calculations when real transactions revealed exceptions.